The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

Iran said it would only observe a two-week ceasefire if **Israel** stopped attacking Lebanon. A news agency affiliated with Iran's security forces also said ships would not be allowed through the Strait of Hormuz while Lebanon was under attack. Donald Trump, meanwhile, told PBS that Lebanon was "not included in the deal". On Wednesday Israel hit over 100 sites in Lebanon allegedly linked to Hizbullah, an Iran-backed Shia militia.

Separately **Gulf states** including Kuwait, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE reported Iranian missile attacks after Iran and America agreed to a ceasefire late on Tuesday. Iran's regime and Mr Trump have very different ideas about the conditions necessary for a lasting peace. Mr Trump insists America will recover Iranian **nuclear** material; Iran wants a right to nuclear enrichment and control over the Strait of Hormuz.

Oil prices fell while **stockmarkets** around the world rose. Brent crude dropped by 13% to around $95 a barrel; before the war it was around $70. The S&P 500 index of big American firms jumped by around 2%, and the yield on ten-year Treasuries fell, as did the value of the dollar against other currencies.

Greece banned children from **social media**. Under-15s will be blocked from sites such as Instagram and TikTok from next year. In a message on TikTok Kyriakos Mitsotakis, Greece's prime minister, said screen-time does not allow minds to rest. Australia has a similar ban, and at least a dozen other countries, including Britain and France, are considering one. They may do more harm than good.

Levi Strauss, an American maker of jeans, reported strong revenue growth in the first quarter of 2026, up by 14% compared with a year earlier. Its shares rose on the news. Strong demand for back-in-fashion baggy jeans boosted sales, despite the firm putting up prices in part to cover import duties arising from Mr Trump's tariffs. A collection with Beyoncé also helped drive sales among young Americans.

Ben Roberts-Smith, a decorated **Australian veteran**, was charged with war crimes related to the killing of five unarmed Afghans in 2009 and 2012. He denies wrongdoing. Mr Roberts-Smith, who was in the special forces during the **Afghanistan** war, is the second veteran to be charged with such crimes since a report, published in 2020, presented evidence of the unlawful killing of civilians by Australia's armed forces.

Meta released a new AI model. "Muse Spark" will not compete with rivals' top models, but is tailored to draw on content posted to the firm's social networks. On Tuesday **Anthropic**, another American firm, said its new "Mythos" model is too powerful to be made available to the public. The company claims to have been alarmed by its software-hacking capabilities.

Figure of the day: 70%, the increase in the price of urea, a fertiliser, since the start of the war in the Gulf. Read about how the conflict could cause a global food shock.

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

What comes after the ceasefire?

As soon as Donald Trump announced a two-week ceasefire in Iran, both sides predictably declared victory. America's president reckons he compelled Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz without first securing a comprehensive truce. The regime thinks that its threats to attack power plants and water-desalination facilities across the Gulf deterred Mr Trump from following through on his threat to destroy "a whole civilisation".

The truth about who will come out on top will only become evident once negotiations between the sides begin, probably in Pakistan on Friday. Mr Trump called Iran's ten-point peace plan "workable"—despite its inclusion of points that cross America's red lines, such as Iranian control of the strait and Iran's right to enrich uranium. America might bargain sanctions relief, unlocking investment needed for Iran's reconstruction (and enriching the regime).

Should talks fail, there is another option: an uneasy return to the status quo of sanctions and American military threats. That would leave Iran with a stockpile of uranium enriched to near-weapons-grade, and strong motivation to build a bomb.

Photograph: Getty Images

A perilous moment for NATO

On Wednesday NATO's secretary-general, Mark Rutte, is expected to meet Donald Trump at the White House. The former Dutch prime minister is known as one of Europe's Trump whisperers. America's president has long criticised NATO and said other members need to increase their defence spending. But he has heralded his working relationship with Mr Rutte, and last year said the secretary-general was doing a "fantastic job". In January Mr Rutte helped to persuade Mr Trump to step back from his threats to seize Greenland, an autonomous Danish territory.

Still, the meeting could be awkward. Furious over allies' refusal to join the Iran war, Mr Trump has said he is considering withdrawing America from NATO. The president may not have the legal power to formally yank his country out. But even the suggestion that NATO's most powerful member would not defend its partners undermines the alliance's credibility as a deterrent. Mr Rutte has his work cut out.

Photograph: Getty Images

America’s rising electricity needs

America’s Energy Information Agency, a government forecaster, releases its outlook for the year ahead on Wednesday. The war in Iran has jolted energy markets, including in largely self-sufficient places like America, making predictions unusually tricky. One thing that is easy to foresee, however, is that America’s electricity demand is set to rise sharply.

Power-hungry data centres are driving much of the increase. The EIA expects most additional demand to be met by gas-fired power plants, already the country’s largest source of electricity and a focus of Donald Trump’s “Unleash American Energy” agenda. Yet the fastest growth is coming from renewables. Falling costs and efficiency gains have given clean energy strong momentum. The EIA reckons 99% of new generating capacity in 2026 will come from solar, wind and batteries—suggesting the energy unleashed may not be quite the kind the White House intends.

Photograph: Getty Images

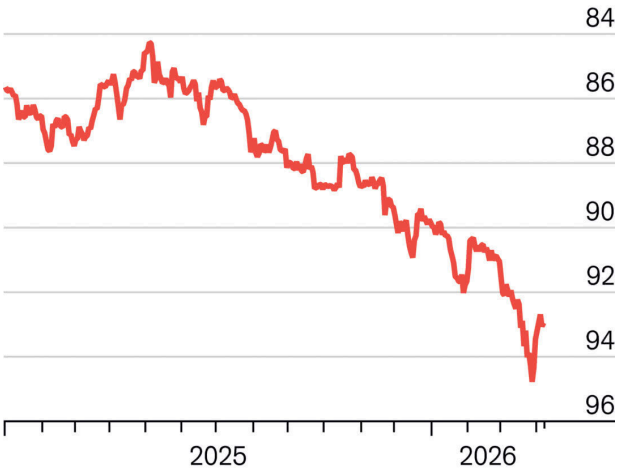
India grapples with a sliding rupee

Last year the Indian rupee was Asia's worst-performing currency, losing 5% of its value against the dollar. The conflict in the Gulf has only deepened the slump. After America and Israel began bombing Iran, the rupee fell by as much as 4%, to a record low of 95 to the dollar on March 27th, prompting India's central bank to intervene. It introduced measures to curb speculative bets against the rupee.

The intervention helped the currency recover. Now the Reserve Bank of India is weighing stronger measures to boost its value, such as raising interest rates. However, on Wednesday at its latest monetary policy meeting the bank held fire. That decision cheered markets—but not as much as the announcement of a ceasefire in the Gulf, which sent Indian stockmarkets soaring but also boosted the value of the rupee.

Ropey

Indian rupees per $, inverted scale



Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: Reuters

Artemis II prepares to come back down to Earth

As the crew aboard Artemis II prepared to travel around the far side of the Moon this week they were woken by a surprise broadcast. “Welcome to my old neighbourhood!” said Jim Lovell, the NASA astronaut who led the first such mission in 1968 (he recorded it shortly before he died last year).

The four astronauts are the first to visit Lovell’s former ends since the Apollo missions concluded in 1972. Their lunar flyby took them 406,773km from Earth—farther than anyone has gone before. Now comes the tricky part. The crew will spend the coming days preparing to re-enter Earth’s atmosphere. Their Orion capsule must withstand temperatures of up to 2,760°C. The heatshield suffered severe damage during the previous (uncrewed) Artemis mission. NASA’s decision to alter the re-entry trajectory rather than redesign the shield itself was criticised by some spaceflight experts. But a successful splashdown in the Pacific Ocean on Friday—the most likely outcome—will take America closer to its goal of a lunar landing in 2028.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Which actress played Princess Leia in the "Star Wars" films?

Tuesday: Which political party won the largest share of the vote in the recent Baden-Wũrttemburg regional election?

Either we are all free, or we fail; democracy must belong to all of us

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Dennis Chavez